

BOOZE BIAS

Law has been diluted in some pockets, but has become stricter for locals

Another hooch tragedy exposes cracks in Gujarat’s dry law

SATISH JHA
AHMEDABAD, DHNS

Another hooch tragedy struck “dry” Gujarat in mid-August, killing 13 people and leaving more than 60 others ill in the Bhavnagar district. They had liquor laced with toxic methanol.

Investigation found that the liquor was consumed at an event celebrating a person’s selection in the Gujarat Police recruitment drive. The aspirant, who also fell ill after consuming the liquor, and others had bought it from a bootlegger — as is prevalent in the state.

The other tragic aspect of the case was that the person who had come up with the formula for making the liquor using methanol also consumed the concoction and passed away.

According to the police, the concoction was manufactured at a makeshift unit and bottled in containers bearing duplicate labels of a popular whisky brand. They were sold to consumers through a chain of bootleggers, exposing fault lines in the state government’s prohibition policy.

A total of 27 suspects have been arrested in connection with the incident, which has once again highlighted how easily illicit liquor continues to be manufactured, distributed, and consumed in Gujarat, right under the nose of the police and administration.

It has also put a big question mark over the implementation of the state’s liquor-prohibition policy, with alcohol flowing in from all its neighbours: Maharashtra, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh.

State’s stand

After visiting those undergoing treatment following the



PROHIBITION PARADOX

Gujarat’s decades-old prohibition policy has failed to prevent deadly hooch tragedies. Here are some of the state’s worst alcohol-poisoning incidents

● Botad and Ahmedabad (July 2022)

In 2022, at least 46 people were killed and about 100 hospitalised in a major alcohol poisoning incident. The victims consumed nearly undiluted methyl alcohol (methanol) sourced illegally from a chemical company employee

● Ahmedabad (July 2009)

One of the state’s worst recorded alcohol poisonings: Methanol-tainted illicit liquor killed nearly 150 people. Many survivors suffered serious illnesses, including vision loss.

● Vadodara (March 1989)

Major illicit-liquor poisoning resulted in 135 fatalities; around 200 people affected

● Sarangpur Daulatkhana, Ahmedabad (1977)

One of Gujarat’s earliest major recorded hooch tragedies; 101 died, 215 people affected

WHY GUJARAT IS ‘DRY’

● Prohibition has been in place since 1960, when Gujarat was formed from the erstwhile Bombay state.

● The policy was retained in part in the name of Mahatma Gandhi, who was born in Gujarat.

● Maharashtra subsequently lifted prohibition, while Gujarat retained it.

The bigger question
● The tragedy highlights how easily illicit liquor is manufactured, distributed and consumed despite prohibition
● Liquor reportedly enters Gujarat from neighbouring Maharashtra, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh
● Raises questions over the implementation and effectiveness of prohibition



After the 2009 tragedy, Gujarat introduced capital punishment for illegal manufacture/sale of toxic alcohol; it became law in 2011.

In 2017, punishment for selling, consuming or transporting illicit liquor was increased to up to 10 years’ imprisonment + Rs 5 lakh fine.

Bhavnagar incident, Gujarat minister Jitu Vaghani was emphatic when he told reporters, “The state government’s position on liquor prohibition policy is clear: There is no question of lifting prohibition... Not yesterday, not today and not tomorrow.”

The ground reality, however, is different. A little digging would reveal that his own government has, over the past three decades, gradually diluted the policy. As a result, it is considerably liberal in 2026.

The government has created pockets where liquor can be legally sold and served in the garb of “ease of doing business” and promoting tourism. The latest tweak in the liquor regime was an exemption for GIFT City — the state government’s pet project where visitors from outside the state can eat and drink without the

hassle of having to obtain a legal permit.

Because of the policy shift, GIFT City — a global financial hub in the state capital of Gandhinagar — now has dedicated “beer bars” and wine-and-dine restaurants. The website of a prominent hotel even mentions “gourmet liquor”. It explains how “challenging” it was to find a bar in Gandhinagar, and that it now offers an “exclusive environment” where “business meets leisure” in a way that was previously prohibited in the state.

In 2023, the Bhupendra Patel-led BJP government first announced relaxation in liquor prohibition laws for establishing wine-and-dine facilities in the GIFT City area, aimed at creating a “global business ecosystem” for “investors, technical experts, [and] national and international firms”.

In 2025, the relaxation was further extended so outsiders — domestic or international — could consume liquor at designated hotels and restaurants simply by showing a photo identity card. They do not have to obtain a liquor permit.

In June this year, the state government, through notifications, slashed value-added tax on foreign liquor served in GIFT City from 65% to 25%. The government also did away with the special fee of Rs 240 on a peg of 30-ml liquor serving. This was done to make pricing similar to other metro cities to create a “social life” that would attract talent from outside.

Similar pockets have been created across the state where liquor laws are relaxed for visitors. On the other hand, laws for locals have only been becoming more stringent.

Education no longer a priority under Modi govt: BJP veteran

NEW DELHI, DHNS

BJP veteran Murli Manohar Joshi, who was the Union education minister during the Atal Bihari Vajpayee era, has said education protests have taken place because the sector is now no longer a priority of the Narendra Modi dispensation.

He also spoke about “corruption” in the judiciary, and said people pay bribes because they see it everywhere.

Speaking to Hindi daily “Amar Ujala”, Joshi said that “the fault” lay with the government and not the people.

“Education is no longer a priority of the government. The road transport budget is constantly increasing. Private industrialisation is a priority, so more money is being spent on it,” Joshi said, adding that

higher education should not be commercialised.

Joshi also said that while there was a demand for a new education policy during Vajpayee’s tenure, they did not feel the need for one as the existing one was good enough.

He added that education should provide employment opportunities and people should not have to resort to paying bribes.

“When people see corruption in the judiciary and the widespread influence of money, they don’t hesitate to resort to this approach. The fault lies with the government, not the people,” he said.

During the Jantar Mantar protests, Joshi had strongly condemned the Delhi Police’s lathi-charge on students, calling the brutal use of force against youth and women “deeply painful”.



Murli Manohar Joshi

IIT-D director threatens action against protesting students

NEW DELHI, DHNS: IIT-Delhi Director Rangan Banerjee on Saturday warned of disciplinary action against students accused of disrupting campus functioning, as protests over the alleged suicide of 31-year-old MSc student Rishikesh Kumar entered the sixth day.

The warning came after demonstrators gathered outside faculty residences late Friday night, with Banerjee alleging that some raised slogans containing “unsavoury, humiliating, and threatening” language.

In a communication to the institute, he described the episode as a departure from peaceful forms of dissent.

“Such behaviour compromises the safety, privacy and peace of faculty members and their families, including young children and elderly dependants,” he said. “The institute will take disciplinary actions against individuals disrupting the peaceful functioning of the

campus, including residential areas, classes, academic and other activities.”

Kumar’s family and fellow students have blamed his death on institutional negligence and caste-based discrimination. Protesters have been demanding an independent inquiry, action against those responsible, and reforms to address marginalised-community students’ concerns.

While reiterating that the institute supported the students’ right to voice their concerns, the director stressed that protests must remain within the framework of the campus rules and not interfere with the institute’s functioning or target the faculty or the staff.

Earlier this week, a probe panel was formed, but the chairperson of the committee, former Uttarakhand DGP and IIT-Dalumunns Alok Kumar, rescused himself citing prior commitments. A new chairperson is yet to be named.

Amid BCI row, Justice Nagarathna calls for an independent, ethical Bar

Reminds lawyers that theirs is an ‘office of trust’, not merely a trade

ASHISH TRIPATHI
NEW DELHI, DHNS

Supreme Court Justice BV Nagarathna on Saturday underscored that an independent Bar is indispensable to constitutional democracy, calling on lawyers and Bar Councils to introspect deeply on their ethics, competence and public utility amid rising concerns over the profession’s direction.

Addressing the 13th convocation of National Law University, Delhi, she stressed that the Bar’s independence is not a personal privilege.

“It existed because a constitutional democracy required a body of professionals who could advise, argue, challenge and represent without having to seek permission from the State, the market or even their clients,” she said.

What she said



“As the legal system in India is bogged down by pendency, delays, rising costs and uncertainty, the Bar in India must rise and speak in a singular voice as to how it could sustain the system of justice dispensation in India

“The lawyers of this country are the torchbearers of the values of our Constitution. Any lapse or errors of the bar will have a deep impact on our political and civic life. Hence, their importance in our society.

“I humbly remind every member of the Bar to change their mindset and endure to work for their clients as a public service, lest they lose their relevance in the future to come. That would be disastrous for our system of dispensation of justice and for preserving the rule of law in our country.

“Lawyers are safety valves of democracies. So do not allow the pursuit of a successful career to make you forget what makes your profession worth preserving in the first place. Guard its independence. Earn its trust,” she added.

Her remarks come against the backdrop of recent controversies involving Bar Council of India (BCI) Chairperson Manan Kumar Mishra. His comments on student protests and actions against NALSAR students triggered widespread criticism within the legal fraternity, prompting calls for his resignation and petitions in the

SC seeking scrutiny of the BCI’s functioning and his tenure.

Justice Nagarathna urged both the central and state Bar Councils to examine their role in upholding professional ethics, morality and competence. “When a Bar Council does not earn the respect of its members, it is not a good sign for the legal profession,” she observed.

The Bar, she said, must rethink its usefulness to litigants, its duty to safeguard democracy, and its responsibility in upholding the majesty of courts and the rule of law.

She recalled the profession’s

historic contributions to the freedom movement and Constitution-making, noting that lawyers remain “torch-bearers of the values of our Constitution.”

Any lapse by the Bar, she warned, would deeply affect the country’s political and civic life. The legal system’s mounting pendency, delays, costs and uncertainty demand that the Bar speak with one voice on sustaining justice delivery.

To the graduating students, Justice Nagarathna described the profession as an “office of trust” rather than a mere trade. A lawyer’s duty extends beyond a client’s instructions, there are times when counsel must firmly advise against an unwise or legally untenable course that harms both the client and the rule of law, she said.

Justice Nagarathna said that lawyers act for individuals but operate within public institutions, carrying dual responsibilities.

She also issued a clear caution against citing AI-generated fake judgments in court. “If arguing before a Court of Law, ensure that fake judgments obtained through AI are not cited. Don’t fall prey to hallucination,” she said.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi being received by Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev upon his arrival in Tashkent. PTI

Looking to advance India’s vision for region free from terror, PM departs for SCO Summit

NEW DELHI, PTI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday left for a two-nation visit to Uzbekistan and the Kyrgyz Republic to attend the SCO summit, saying he looked forward to advancing India’s vision for the organisation and working with fellow members for a region free from the scourge of terrorism.

Modi, who will first visit Uzbekistan (August 29-30) and then attend the summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyz Republic (August 30-September 1), also said he was confident

that his tour will strengthen India’s strategic partnerships in Central Asia and deepen the civilisational connect with the region.

In his departure statement, Modi said the trip will advance the shared pursuit of peace, stability and prosperity, values that lie at the heart of India’s engagement with the world.

“India has been an active and constructive member of the SCO since 2017. I look forward to advancing India’s vision for the region, anchored in Security, Connectivity and

Opportunity, and to working with fellow members for a region free from the scourge of terrorism, separatism and extremism, which continue to threaten peace and stability in our neighbourhood and beyond,” he said.

The PM said that at the invitation of President Shavkat Mirziyoyev, he will visit Tashkent on August 29-30 for a state visit to Uzbekistan.

In recent years, the India-Uzbekistan strategic partnership has seen significant advancement, he said.

Ban on hing powder sold by Everest, Laljee Godhoo

NEW DELHI, PTI: Food regulator FSSAI on Saturday said it has prohibited Everest Food Products Pvt Ltd and Laljee Godhoo from selling hing powder, which it found to be substandard.

In a social media post, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) informed that it has issued prohibition orders against Everest Food Products and Laljee Godhoo and Company, as their products, ‘hing powder’ were found to be substandard.

In the case of Everest, FSSAI has prohibited the sale of compounded asafetida (hing

powder) variants with immediate effect.

“The samples of compounded asafetida (hing powder) were found to be ‘misbranded and substandard’ by the food analyst of the primary food laboratory,” the regulator said.

The articles were found to be in contravention of the provisions of the FSS (Food Products and Food Additives) Regulations, 2011, and the alcohol-soluble extract obtained was 0% against the prescribed standard of not less than 5%.

In the case of Laljee Godhoo,

FSSAI said the company has been prohibited from selling hing powder, which it found to be substandard and adulterated.

“The samples... (were) not conforming to the prescribed requirements under the FSS (Food Products and Food Additives) Regulations, 2011,” it added.

The regulator has asked both companies to submit an action plan for rectification of the malpractice and measures to ensure that only standard products are manufactured and sold.



‘Overboard, pedantic’: HC raps Maha FDA

MUMBAI, PTI: The Bombay High Court on Saturday dealt a double blow to the Maharashtra FDA, forcing the regulator to backtrack on two major enforcement actions after being admonished for acting against the “principles of natural justice” and taking a “pedantic instead of pragmatic view.”

Pulling up the FDA for showing “undue haste” in passing orders without analysing the law in connection with eateries on the Mumbai Cricket Association premises, the HC asked: “Do you feel you are a Lord and you can

do anything?”

In the first instance, the FDA withdrew its order cancelling the drug sale licence of Cipla Pharma and Life Sciences Limited’s unit in Pune after a bench of Acting Chief Justice Ravindra Ghuge and Justice Gautam Ankhad scolded the regulator for going “overboard” and behaving in a “high-handed” manner.

In a separate setback for the agency, the FDA informed the court that it would also withdraw its order suspending the operations of five restaurants at the MCA premises in Bandra-Kurla Complex after the

“You (FDA) are doing a laudable and appreciative job, but now you are going overboard. This is not the first time this is happening. You have wronged, and now you have to resolve the issue
Bombay High Court

court warned of stinging orders against officials, noting that a fresh inspection showed the eateries were 88% compliant with food safety rules.

However, the licences of eateries remained suspended as they were being operated

by another entity, M/s Shirke Infrastructure, despite the licences being issued in MCA’s name.

When warned of contempt action, the FDA said it would issue a fresh notice to MCA and grant them a hearing on the issue of the contract between the association and Shirke Infrastructure and then pass a reasoned order.

The court accepted this and said that since the eateries are now compliant with the rules, the order suspending their licenses stands vacated, and they can reopen their services.

Kishtwar case transferred

JAMMU, PTI: Probe into the rape and subsequent death of a 15-year-old girl in Kishtwar district has been handed over to the Crime Branch, officials said on Saturday.

The teen was allegedly raped by her school teacher over several months. She died on August 20 during a pregnancy termination procedure.

A police SIT has so far arrested six persons in connection with the case, including the alleged rapist teacher and a nurse.